ConnectLoop Project Proposal

A care-centred social web application for newcomers in Brisbane

Project Definition

ConnectLoop is a proposed social web application that helps newcomers in Brisbane build meaningful local connections through shared interests, low-pressure group activities, and flexible relationship milestones. The project responds to the question developed in tutorial work: how can we help people make new connections in a foreign environment? The initial problem space includes exchange students, people who have recently moved for work or study, stay-at-home partners, remote workers, and introverted users who may want social contact but feel anxious about entering unfamiliar groups.

Moving to a new city often interrupts ordinary routines of friendship. Newcomers may not know where to meet people, which events are suitable for beginners, how much social effort will be expected, or whether they will be forced into uncomfortable introductions. Existing social platforms often emphasise broad discovery, public profiles, fast messaging, or event attendance, but they do not always support the uncertain, gradual and emotionally sensitive process of becoming socially comfortable in a new place. ConnectLoop therefore treats connection as a paced journey rather than a quick match.

The proposed setting is community-based social activity in Brisbane, especially small activities in public or semi-public places such as South Bank, campus common rooms, cafes, libraries and community spaces. Users begin by selecting interests such as photography, cooking, running, movies, gaming or study, along with communication preferences, language comfort, and social comfort level. The system then recommends small interest-based circles that are marked as newcomer-friendly, nearby and low-pressure.

The main user scenario follows Noah, a person who has recently moved to Brisbane and wants to meet people but feels nervous about joining a group alone. Noah selects photography, English and Mandarin as comfortable languages, and a preference for small groups. ConnectLoop recommends a Photography Walk with four to six members. Before joining, Noah can preview the schedule, meeting point, expected group size, host name, language options and a reassurance that he will not be asked to introduce himself in front of everyone. He can choose whether to simply join the activity, meet one person first, or ask the host to greet him on arrival. After the event, Noah privately selects people he would like to stay connected with. A connection is created only when both people choose each other.

The design solution has four main phases. First, onboarding makes user needs explicit without demanding a public identity performance. Second, discovery recommends small interest circles rather than large anonymous events. Third, event support provides clear expectations and activity prompts so that conversation can start around shared doing, not only self-presentation. Fourth, reconnecting after the activity supports mutual consent, optional next steps, and flexible milestones such as first conversation, talking on three different days, or one month connected. These milestones are intended as gentle continuity markers, not scores that rank users.

Significance of Proposed Interaction

The core interaction in ConnectLoop is a transition from digital preparation to embodied social participation. The application does not replace face-to-face connection with online chatting; instead, it supports people before, during and after local activities. This is important because the hardest part of making friends in a new environment is often the moment of entry: deciding whether a group feels safe, finding the meeting point, starting a first conversation, and knowing whether further contact is mutually welcome.

The interaction qualities are care, predictability, agency, low pressure, reciprocity and continuity. Care is expressed through host support, newcomer-friendly labels, and the option to ask for a gentle introduction. Predictability appears in detailed event previews, clear schedules and preparation guides. Agency is central because users choose their comfort level and can pause conversations without losing a connection. Low pressure is achieved by encouraging shared activities, such as taking photos that represent Brisbane, rather than pushing users to perform socially. Reciprocity matters because post-event connection requires mutual confirmation. Continuity is supported through subtle milestones and optional future activities.

The modalities combine form-based preference selection, visual event cards, private comfort settings, messaging, reminders, activity prompts and in-person social action. For example, a Photography Walk card shows time, place, group size, tags such as relaxed or new group, and languages. A preparation screen gives practical details such

as where to meet and who the host is. During the activity, a prompt such as taking three photos that represent Brisbane gives members something concrete to do and talk about. Afterward, a reconnect screen asks who the user met and whether they would like to stay connected.

This interaction approach is significant because it recognises that social confidence varies. Some people are comfortable approaching a group immediately, while others need a path that starts with observation, preparation, or one-to-one introduction. The design avoids assuming that extroverted behaviour is the norm. It also treats social participation as situated: users may behave differently depending on language, culture, past experience, time pressure, personal circumstances and the specific environment. In this sense, ConnectLoop aligns with values-oriented HCI, where values and ethics are not separate from design but should be surfaced as part of design practice (Shilton, 2018).

The application also reflects the idea that technologies mediate human action. Verbeek (2006) argues that designed artefacts can shape what users do by inviting, discouraging or organising particular behaviours. ConnectLoop therefore must be designed carefully because its interface will influence how newcomers interpret social risk, how hosts support participants, and how connections are continued. The aim is to inscribe gentle social support into the interaction while avoiding manipulative pressure.

Ethical Issues and Action Plan

The ethical issues in ConnectLoop are not secondary risks; they are central to whether the project succeeds. Because the application deals with social vulnerability, location, personal preferences and private relationships, the design must protect users while still helping them enter real community spaces. The following table identifies key ethical concerns and practical actions.

Ethical issue	Why it matters	Action plan	Design value
Privacy of personal preferences	Comfort level, language and social anxiety can reveal sensitive information.	Make comfort settings visible only to hosts or staff when needed; use plain consent controls; allow users to edit or delete preferences.	Privacy
Consent in reconnecting	A user may feel uncomfortable if another person can contact them after an event without permission.	Create a connection only after both users opt in; hide non-mutual selections; provide block and report tools.	Reciprocity
Physical safety at activities	The app moves users from online discovery into real-world meetings.	Prefer public venues; verify hosts; show meeting points; provide check-in, emergency guidance and event reporting.	Safety
Pressure through rewards	Milestones or XP could make friendship feel like a performance or competition.	Use private, optional progress markers; avoid rankings, streak loss and public scores; frame milestones as reflection, not achievement.	Care
Exclusion and bias	Matching by language or interests could isolate users or reproduce social bubbles.	Offer diverse circle recommendations; include newcomer-friendly mixed groups; monitor whether some users are repeatedly excluded.	Inclusion
Host power and responsibility	Hosts can see support needs and shape the tone of the group.	Give hosts training prompts, privacy rules and moderation tools; limit what hosts can see; review complaints.	Accountability
Data retention	Relationship histories and attendance records could become unnecessary long-term social data.	Collect the minimum data needed; set retention periods; allow users to export and delete their data.	Autonomy
Cultural misunderstanding	Newcomers may have different expectations around conversation, privacy and friendship.	Use inclusive language, multilingual support, clear event norms and optional written activity instructions.	Respect

These actions follow an anticipatory approach to ethics. Kudina and Verbeek (2019) show that technologies and values can change together as people encounter new forms of mediation. For ConnectLoop, this means privacy, comfort and social obligation should be evaluated through testing with newcomers and hosts, not assumed once at the start. Early prototype sessions should ask users what information they feel comfortable sharing, what types of prompts feel supportive, and when guidance becomes pressure. This feedback should be used to revise the interface before wider deployment.

Conclusion

ConnectLoop proposes a care-centred way to help newcomers form local relationships at their own pace. Its contribution is not simply to recommend events, but to redesign the fragile transition between wanting connection and entering a new social space. By combining interest-based circles, clear previews, comfort-level choices, shared activities, mutual reconnection and flexible milestones, the application supports people who may otherwise remain isolated. The ethical challenge is to ensure that the same technology that makes connection easier does not expose vulnerability, pressure users, or turn friendship into measurable performance. For this reason, privacy, consent, safety and inclusion must remain core design requirements throughout the project.

AI Acknowledgement

This proposal draft was prepared with assistance from ChatGPT/Codex to structure the report, refine academic wording, and organise ethical issues from the supplied tutorial materials and readings. Before submission, the final author should review the content, revise it to reflect their own design decisions and add a shareable public link to the AI chat if required by the course.

References

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